

JAMES WILD & CO. · COSTA RICA · 9°56′N 84°05′W · SINCE 1991

Costa Rica, *the Long Way Round*

A field guide to Costa Rica's surf breaks, rainforest lodges and wild coasts, from a surf pioneer of 1991

JAMES WILD & CO. · LEDGERED & VETTED · JOURNEY DESIGN SINCE 1982

PREPARED FOR

Jane Traveler

TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

COVER · THE PACIFIC COAST AT DUSK · GETTY IMAGES

A LETTER BEFORE YOU GO

Dear Jane,

I first came to Costa Rica in 1991 with a surfboard, a map that was mostly guesswork and a rental car that was mostly rust. After a few short jaunts to the Bahamas and selling my very first surf trip, this was where I branched out. We ran one of the first surf and adventure travel companies here, Adventure Expeditions, and we spent the early nineties finding and mapping the breaks, all the way up into Nicaragua and down into Panama. Later I worked as a wholesaler for many of the big travel brands, which is a polite way of saying I drove every bad road so their guests wouldn't have to.

We got stuck. A lot. We took the wrong turn so often it became the route. We drove into rivers and, more than once, never reached the other side. Small planes landed on dirt strips after someone ran out to shoo the cows off the runway. Before you sat down anywhere, you checked the rafters for hornet nests. It was raw, it was wild and it was very, very cheap.

Well, now. The roads are paved (mostly), the lodges are some of the finest in the Americas, and the price has caught up with the view. The waves, the forest and the people haven't changed a bit. That's why I keep going back, and why I still know which road not to take.

This guide is page one of your Folio. Mark it up. Circle what makes you grin. Cross out what doesn't. When we talk, I'll already know which kind of traveler you are.

J. Wild CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER · COSTA RICA SINCE 1991

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

	1991, when I first came	Today
VISITORS	About 504,000 international visitors	Nearly 2.95 million (2025)
THE WAY IN	Dirt roads, river fords and a few grass airstrips	Two international airports, San José and Liberia, and paved roads to most coasts
THE PRICE	Raw and very inexpensive	Well, now...

How to read the marks in this guide

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

The places James has gone back to since 1991.

I KNOW A PLACE
I slept here

James has stayed or surfed there himself.

I KNOW WHO KNOWS
partner vetted

Vetted through a partner we trust.

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

On James's list. Recommended, honestly marked.

IN THIS GUIDE

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Read it north to south, the way we mapped it. Or start with the page that made you pick it up.

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"I've taken every wrong turn in Costa Rica. That's how I know the right ones."

J. Wild

Two oceans, one long afternoon apart



◀ PACIFIC · GUANACASTE, NICOYA, OSA

CARIBBEAN · TORTUGUERO, PUERTO VIEJO ▶



The local mascot. He does not do mornings either

A small country with a big address book

Costa Rica holds nearly 6% of the world's biodiversity on about 0.03% of its surface: rainforest, cloud forest, dry forest, mangrove and two oceans of reef, all within a day's drive.

Green on purpose

More than a quarter of the land is protected in national parks and reserves. The country abolished its army in 1948 and has spent the savings on schools, parks and, it sometimes seems, frogs.

Surf on both coasts

Pacific swells from spring to autumn, Caribbean reef breaks in the northern winter, and in the right month you can surf both in a single day if you leave before breakfast.

LINGER LONGER *"Costa Rica is small enough to cross in a day and big enough to keep surprising you for thirty-five years." — J. W.*

Dry, green, and the swell in between

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Pacific, dry season	•	•	•	•	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	•
Caribbean coast	○	•	•	○	○	○	○	○	•	•	○	○
South swells (Pacific)	○	○	○	○	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	○
Guanacaste offshore	•	•	•	•	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	•
Caribbean surf	•	•	•	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	•	•
Turtles, Tortuguero	○	○	○	○	○	○	•	•	•	•	○	○
Humpbacks, Uvita	•	•	•	○	○	○	•	•	•	•	○	•

• Prime months ○ Possible, with more rain, wind or a smaller swell. Guidance only; nature keeps her own calendar.

DECEMBER – APRIL

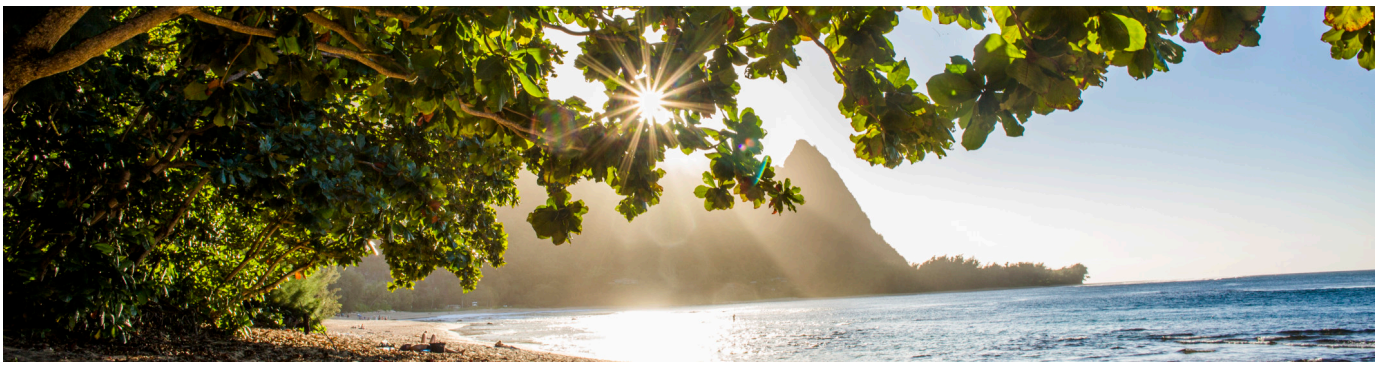
The dry season

Blue skies on the Pacific side, offshore winds in Guanacaste and the easiest roads. Also the busiest months, so book the good lodges early.

MAY – NOVEMBER

The green season

Sunny mornings, afternoon downpours, empty line-ups and the biggest south swells. My favourite time, and the forest agrees.



Where the forest meets the Pacific

In 1992 the rainy season taught me the difference between a road and a river. The map can't tell you. I can.

– J. Wild

Who Costa Rica is for, and who it isn't

The short answer: almost everyone, as long as you don't mind a little rain and a lot of green. Here's how I'd match you, by the kind of traveler you are.

BEST FOR	IDEAL LENGTH	BEST TIME	HOW
Surfers, families, wildlife lovers and anyone who likes a little mud with their luxury	10 to 14 days: two coasts and the volcano	Dec–Apr dry; May–Nov for south swells and empty line-ups	Lodges and villas, linked by small plane and 4x4

MADE FOR YOU IF YOU'RE…

First-timers

Volcano, cloud forest, beach. The greatest hits, in the right order.

OUR PICK · VOLCANO, CLOUD & WILD · 10 DAYS

Surfers, any level

From the first wave of your life to the last left in Pavones.

OUR PICK · THE LONG WAY ROUND

Families with kids

Sloths before breakfast, ziplines after lunch, frogs at bedtime.

OUR PICK · NAYARA OR PACUARE, THEN THE BEACH

Couples & honeymooners

Seven rooms, a wood-fired hot tub and the howler monkeys as your alarm clock.

OUR PICK · ORIGINS LODGE

Wildlife lovers

Corcovado is the real thing. Tapirs, scarlet macaws, four kinds of monkey.

OUR PICK · LAPA RIOS, OSA PENINSULA

Wellness seekers

Hot springs at Arenal, yoga in Nosara, nothing on the calendar.

OUR PICK · NAYARA SPRINGS, THEN NOSARA

THINK TWICE IF YOU'RE…

Anyone in a hurry

The map says two hours. The road says four. Costa Rica agrees with the road.

OUR PICK · FLY BETWEEN REGIONS; STAY LONGER IN FEWER

Perfect-weather people

It's a rainforest. It rains. That's the deal.

OUR PICK · GO DECEMBER TO APRIL, PACIFIC SIDE

Big-city nightlife

Here, the night shift is frogs, fireflies and a tree full of howlers.

OUR PICK · TWO NIGHTS IN SAN JOSÉ, THEN OUT

Limited mobility

Muddy trails, river landings, tender boats.

OUR PICK · PAPAGAYO RESORTS AND GENTLER LODGES; TELL US AND WE'LL PLAN IT

Bug-phobic

Something will crawl past. It's probably harmless. Probably.

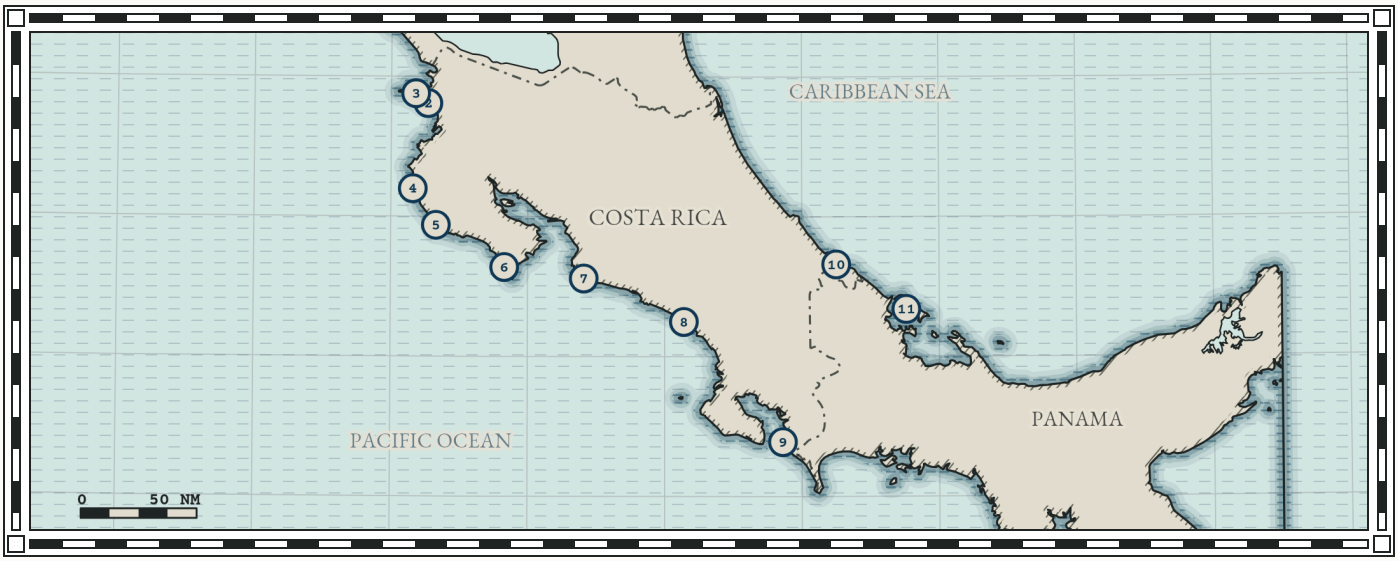
OUR PICK · DRY-SEASON GUANACASTE, SCREENED SUITES

Minimum ages for rafting, ziplines and some lodges apply `[confirm per property]`. If you're not sure where you fit, that's what the call is for.

I KEEP GOING BACK
mapped 1990s

From Popoyo to Santa Catalina

In the early nineties, Adventure Expeditions charted the surf of Central America one dirt road at a time: north into Nicaragua, along both of Costa Rica's coasts and south into Panama. These are the breaks I still send people to, numbered on the map.



Positions approximate. Sizes, seasons and access change: surf with a local guide, respect the line-up; some breaks are reached only by boat or across private land.

01 Popoyo · NICARAGUA · RIVAS
Reef, point and beach peaks with near-constant offshore winds off Lake Nicaragua. The outer reef is for experts.

02 Witch's Rock · SANTA ROSA NATIONAL PARK
Roca Bruja: a rock and rivermouth wave that can barrel, about 45 minutes by permitted boat from Playas del Coco.

03 Ollie's Point · SANTA ROSA NATIONAL PARK
A long right-hand point, best low to mid tide. Boat only, park fee paid.

04 Playa Negra · NEAR TAMARINDO
A reef right that tubes at low to mid tide. Get there before the wind does.

05 Nosara · Playa Guiones · NICOYA PENINSULA
Peeling sand-bottom peaks with a friendly inside. The best place in the country to learn.

06 Santa Teresa · Mal País · NICOYA PENINSULA
Rock-ledge rights and lefts that barrel on the right tide; left points at the south end.

07 Playa Hermosa · NEAR JACÓ
A powerful multi-peak beach break that fires in August.

08 Dominical · SOUTH PACIFIC
Punchy beach break below the jungle, with whales offshore in season.

09 Pavones · GOLFO DULCE
One of the longest lefts in the world, rides up to about a kilometre on a south-southwest swell.

10 Salsa Brava · PUERTO VIEJO · CARIBBEAN
A hollow right over shallow reef, the country's heaviest wave. November to March, experts only.

11 Bocas del Toro · PANAMA · CARIBBEAN
Reef breaks at Paunch, Bluff, Carenero and Silverbacks, best in the northern winter.

12 Santa Catalina · PANAMA · VERAGUAS
La Punta, a rocky point that breaks left and right and gets big. March to October.

FROM THE ORIGINAL LOGBOOK

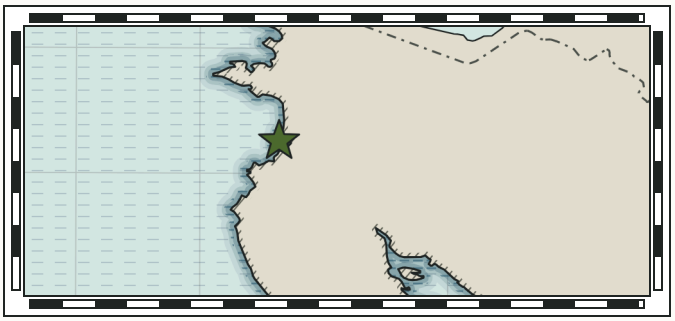
1991
Wrong turn outside Liberia. Found a perfect empty point. Kept the wrong turn.

1992
Drove into a river at high tide. The river won. We waded to the far bank; the car stayed for supper.

1993
The pilot did one low pass to clear the cows, a second to clear the cows that came back, then landed.

Every year
Before sitting down: check the rafters for hornets. Then sit down.

Six regions, two oceans



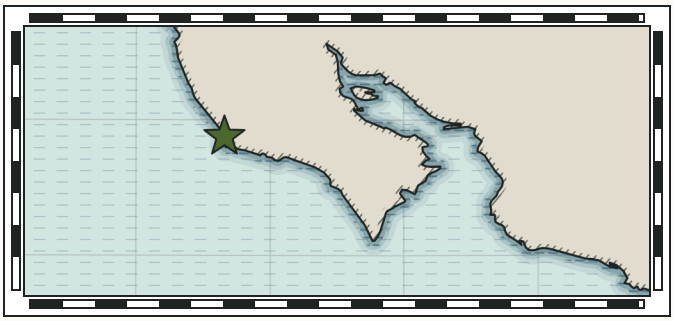
Guanacaste & Papagayo

The dry northwest

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Witch's Rock and Ollie's Point by boat, Papagayo's sheltered bays, and Rincón de la Vieja's volcanoes inland.

Surf & resorts · Four Seasons Papagayo



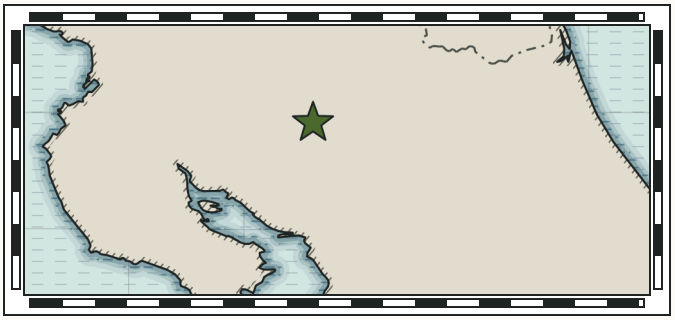
The Nicoya Peninsula

Nosara to Santa Teresa

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Beach breaks, yoga towns and long dirt roads between them. Still the most fun drive in the country.

Surf & yoga · Harmony, Nosara



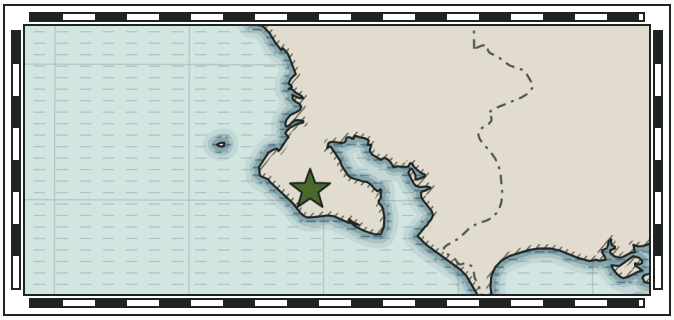
Arenal & the north

Volcano and hot springs

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

The perfect cone of Arenal, hot rivers, hanging bridges and the cloud forest of Monteverde next door.

Springs & bridges · Nayara Springs



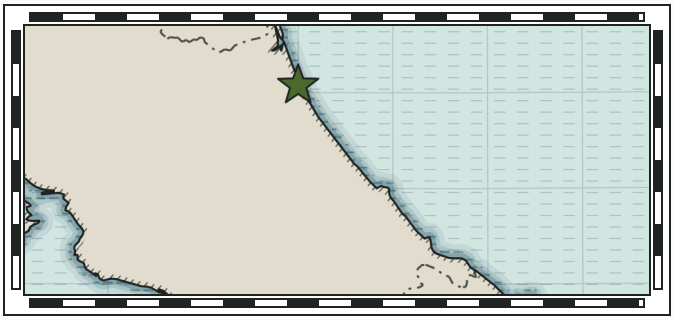
The Osa Peninsula

Corcovado

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

The wildest corner: rainforest to the tideline, scarlet macaws, tapirs and humpbacks offshore.

Rainforest & whales · Lapa Rios



The Caribbean coast

Tortuguero to Puerto Viejo

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Turtle beaches and canals in the north; reggae, reef and Salsa Brava in the south.

Turtles & reef · Boat from La Pavona



Over the border

Nicaragua & Panama

I KEEP GOING BACK
mapped 1990s

Where we went when Costa Rica got crowded, in 1993. Popoyo to the north, Bocas and Santa Catalina to the south.

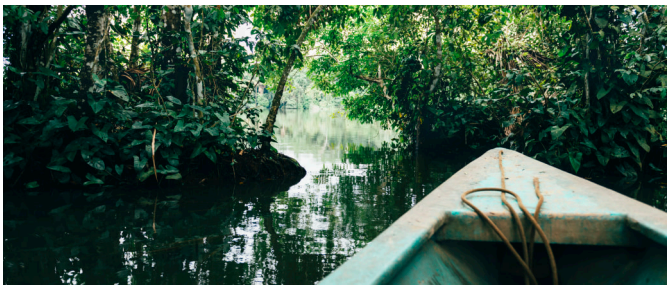
Surf trips · Ask James

Sample stamps for layout. James confirms each mark before release.

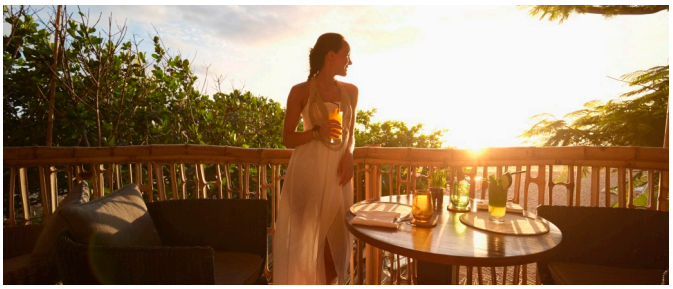
IV · THREE WAYS TO SEE IT

By board, by lodge, or both

	THE SURF COAST	THE WILD INTERIOR	BOTH · THE CONTRAST
Where you sleep	Beach villas and surf lodges	Rainforest lodges and hot-spring villas	A Papagayo suite, then a jungle bungalow
Reach	Guanacaste, Nicoya, the south Pacific	Pacuare, Arenal, Monteverde, Osa	Papagayo, then the Osa Peninsula
Pace	Dawn patrol, long lunch, sunset session	Early walks, rivers, big dinners	Slow, then wild
Getting around	4x4 with a driver who knows the rivers	Small planes and private transfers	One flight across the country
Suits	Surfers, families, friends	First-timers, wildlife lovers	Couples, honeymoons, mixed groups
Nights	7–14	8–12	4 + 4
From	`$[____] pp`	`$[____] pp`	`$[____] pp`



By boat, where the road gives up



Sundowners above the canopy

The linger-o-meter

The same small country at three speeds. What each adds, and what you miss without it.

7

DAYS · ONE COAST

Arenal and one beach, or one surf coast done properly.

You miss: the Osa, and the other ocean.

10

DAYS · VOLCANO, CLOUD & WILD

River, volcano and rainforest, by small plane.

You miss: the surf. Bring a board anyway.

14

DAYS · THE LONG WAY ROUND

Guanacaste to Pavones, every break worth the drive.

You miss: nothing but the cows on the runway.

LINGER LONGER *"Fly over the bad roads, drive the beautiful ones. I learned which is which so you don't have to." — J. W.*

The Long Way Round

JW-CR-S01 · 14 DAYS · LIBERIA TO PAVONES · 4X4 WITH DRIVER, BOAT DAYS

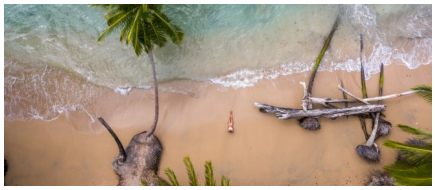
I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991



L Liberia · 1 Ollie's Point & Witch's Rock by boat · 2 Playa Negra · 3 Nosara · 4 Santa Teresa · 5 Dominical · 6 Pavones. Swell decides the order.



Duck under, then go again



Empty beach, full tank



Above and below the waterline

Days 1–3	**Papagayo.** Boat out to Ollie's Point and Witch's Rock, back for dinner by the bay.
Days 4–5	**Playa Negra.** The reef right, early, before the wind turns.
Days 6–8	**Nosara.** Beach peaks, yoga, and the best breakfast on the coast.
Days 9–10	**Santa Teresa.** Ferry-free, if you take the long way. We do.
Days 11–12	**Dominical & Uvita.** Beach breaks and, in season, humpbacks offshore.
Days 13–14	**Pavones.** One of the longest lefts on earth. Then fly home from Golfito.

WHO IT SUITS

Surfers from intermediate up, surf families, and anyone who wants to see the coast I mapped.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 13 nights

TIME REWARDED

Add Nicaragua or Panama for the full 1990s run: [__] off the third week.

TR-CRS-JW-F-0001

QR

Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Give Pavones three days. It needs a south swell, and the swell needs persuading." — J. W.*

Volcano, Cloud & Wild

JW-CR-W01 · 10 DAYS · SAN JOSÉ · PACUARE · ARENAL · OSA · SMALL PLANES

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit



S San José · 1 Pacuare River · 2 Arenal · 3 Osa Peninsula. One raft, two small planes, no wrong turns.



Class III to IV, and that's the warm-up



Cloud-forest detail



Humpbacks off the south Pacific coast

Day 1	**San José.** Land, sleep, eat well.
Days 2–3	**Pacuare.** Raft in to the lodge. There is no road, which is the point.
Days 4–6	**Arenal.** Hot springs, hanging bridges, the volcano at dawn.
Days 7–9	**The Osa.** Corcovado on foot, the Pacific by boat, whales in season.
Day 10	**Home.** Small plane to San José, connect out.

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers, families with kids eight and up, and wildlife lovers.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 9 nights

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night in the Osa: [__].

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QR

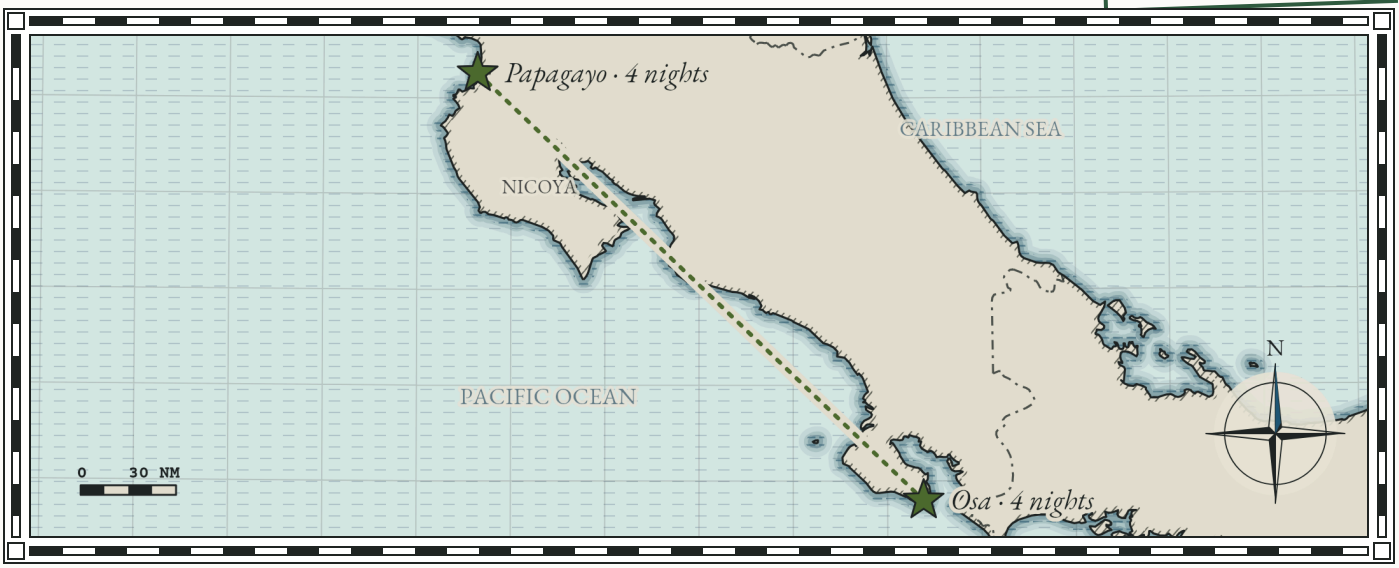
Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Take the dawn walk in Corcovado. The forest is loudest before breakfast, and so are the macaws." — J. W.*

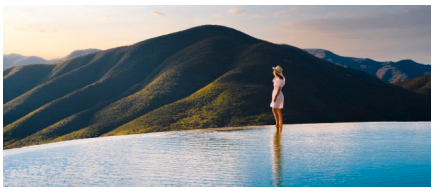
The Contrast

JW-CON-C01 · 4 NIGHTS PAPAGAYO, THEN 4 NIGHTS IN THE OSA · 9 DAYS

I KEEP GOING BACK
the James Wild way



Papagayo, four nights · then one small-plane hop south to the Osa Peninsula



The other kind of long way round



Everyone on one terrace



Where the forest meets the Pacific

Days 1–4	**Papagayo.** Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo. Calm bays, a surf day by boat, long dinners.
Day 5	**Fly south.** Over the Nicoya and down the coast to Puerto Jiménez.
Days 5–8	**The Osa.** Lapa Rios: rainforest at the door, the Pacific below.
Day 9	**Home.** Back via San José or Liberia.

WHO IT SUITS

Couples, honeymooners, and anyone who wants polish first and mud second.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 8 nights

THE CONTRAST RATE

Both stays priced together: [__].

CON-CR-JW-F-0001

QR

Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Good journeys have seams. Polish, then mud. You should feel the change." — J. W.*

Small planes, big rivers

Costa Rica is small on the map and large on the ground. The trick is knowing when to fly, when to drive and when to let the river decide.

PHOTO TO LICENSE · GETTY 1695657254

Small planes

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS · DIRT AND PAVED STRIPS · 20–60 MIN

Two domestic airlines, SANSA and Costa Rica Green Airways, link San José to the coasts: Nosara, Tambor, Tamarindo, Quepos, Golfito, Puerto Jiménez, Drake Bay and Tortuguero. Some strips are paved now. Some are not. The cows have mostly moved on.

PHOTO TO LICENSE · GETTY 1297975323

4x4, with a driver

PRIVATE TRANSFERS · RIVER FORDS INCLUDED

A good driver knows which rivers to cross and which to admire from the bank. We learned the hard way, so you can learn the easy way.



Boats

TORTUGUERO CANALS · OSA · OLLIE'S POINT

Some of the best of Costa Rica has no road at all. Tortuguero is reached by canal, Ollie's Point by sea, parts of the Osa by panga.



Rafts

PACUARE RIVER · CLASS III–IV

The only way into Pacuare Lodge is down the river. Your bags go by road; you go by raft. Nobody has ever asked to swap.

In 1991 the runway check was simple: one low pass to move the cows, one to make sure they stayed moved. These days there's a windsock and, usually, no cows.
— J. Wild

Seven stays, coast to cloud forest



1 Nayara Springs · 2 Lapa Rios Lodge · 3 Pacuare Lodge · 4 Origins Lodge · 5 Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo · 6 Hacienda AltaGracia · 7 Harmony Hotel Nosara

> *Split it in two: one night in a jungle lodge is worth three in a city hotel. Two nights minimum anywhere you have to fly to.*
> *— J. Wild*

Room counts and facilities from the properties' published listings; confirm with each property. Partner photography to follow.

1 Nayara Springs

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

ARENAL · LA FORTUNA

Thirty-five adults-only villas facing the volcano, each with a private plunge pool fed by mineral hot springs.

Best for: Couples and anyone who likes a hot soak with a view.

2 Lapa Rios Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

OSA PENINSULA · CABO MATAPALO

Seventeen bungalows on a private rainforest reserve where the Golfo Dulce meets the Pacific. Whales from the veranda in season.

Best for: Wildlife lovers and the properly curious.

3 Pacuare Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

PACUARE RIVER

Twenty suites and villas in the forest, reached by whitewater raft. The Canopy Suite has its own suspension bridge.

Best for: Families with teens and adventurous couples.

4 Origins Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

RINCÓN DE LA VIEJA · TENORIO

Seven rooms and villas with views to the volcanoes and Lake Nicaragua, and wood-fired hot tubs of their own.

Best for: Honeymooners and anyone hiding from the world.

5 Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

GUANACASTE · PAPAGAYO

182 rooms, suites and villas on a forested peninsula between two beaches, newly renovated with plunge-pool canopy suites.

Best for: Families, three generations and surf by boat.

6 Hacienda AltaGracia

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

PÉREZ ZELEDÓN · TALAMANCA

Fifty casitas on a coffee and horse estate in the southern mountains, from Auberge Resorts.

Best for: Riders, coffee lovers and a quiet reset.

7 Harmony Hotel Nosara

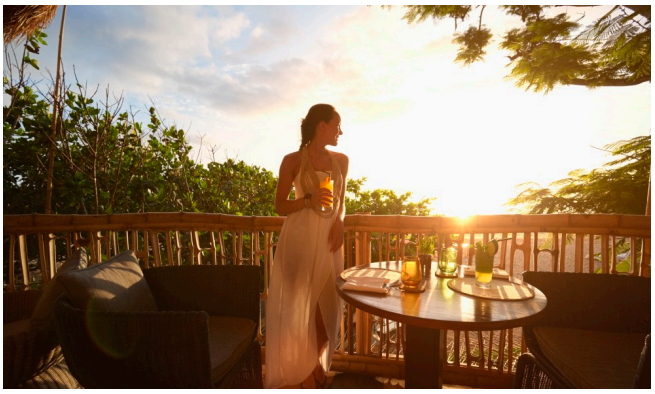
I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

NOSARA · PLAYA GUIONES

Twenty-four rooms and two villas a short walk through the trees to Guiones, with an open-air yoga pavilion.

Best for: Surfers, yogis and slow mornings.

Slower is the whole point



Sundowners above the canopy

Most Costa Rica regrets are about driving, not money. People try to see six regions in eight days and spend most of it behind a truck full of pineapples. We'd rather you stayed.

That's why we plan two or three bases, fly between the far ones, and reward staying longer rather than booking sooner.

Three nights or don't unpack. The first day you hear the howlers. The third day you stop noticing them. That's when you've arrived.
— J. Wild

TIME REWARDED

The Long Way Round

Fourteen days, coast to coast: `[__]` off the second week.

TR-CRS-JW-F-0001

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night in the Osa

`[offer to confirm with the property]`

WAN-CRW-JW-F-0001

ON THE HORIZON

The 1990s run

Costa Rica, Nicaragua and Panama by board, the way we mapped it: early-planner savings of `[__]`.

OTH-CA-JW-F-0001

Codes are tied to your Folio ID so your advisor sees which offer you chose.

VIII · THE LEDGER

The Costa Rica entries

ENTRY	PLACE	MARK	MARGIN NOTE
L-301	Witch's Rock & Ollie's Point · Guanacaste	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*Go by boat, go early, and bring the good wax.*
L-302	Pavones · Golfo Dulce	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*Worth the drive. Worth the wait. Worth the paddle back.*
L-303	Nosara & Playa Guiones · Nicoya	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*Still the friendliest line-up on the coast.*
L-304	Salsa Brava · Puerto Viejo	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*Shallow reef, heavy wave. Watch first.*
L-305	Lapa Rios · Osa Peninsula	I'LL KNOW SOON well worth the visit	*On the list for my next run south.*
L-306	Nayara Springs · Arenal	I'LL KNOW SOON well worth the visit	*Hot springs in your own villa. Asking for a friend.*

Sample entries for layout. Every stamp is confirmed by James before release.

Rules of the Road

01 **If in doubt, don't cross the river.** Rule learned in 1992. Paid for in 1992.

02 **Fly the far ones.** A 40-minute flight beats a nine-hour drive, every time.

03 **Dawn is the good part.** Surf, birds and wildlife all keep early hours.

04 **Check the rafters.** For hornets. Old habit. Good habit.

Words we've struck out

~~UNDISCOVERED~~ — The surfers found it in the sixties. The Ticos found it long before that.

~~OFF THE BEATEN PATH~~ — In 1991, there was no path. Now there's a very good one, and we'll take you past the end of it.

~~PARADISE~~ — Paradise doesn't have hornets. Costa Rica is better than paradise.

What to know, and what not to expect

Getting there

Two international airports: Juan Santamaría (SJO) near San José, and Daniel Oduber (LIR) at Liberia for Guanacaste and the Nicoya. Arrive in daylight if you can.

At the border

US citizens need a passport valid for the length of the stay and proof of onward travel; stays of up to 180 days without a visa are allowed at the officer's discretion. The $29 departure tax is usually included in the airfare `[confirm per airline]`.

Getting around

Fly between the far regions with SANSA or Costa Rica Green Airways, or by private charter. Drive the short legs with a private driver. Luggage limits on small planes are strict; pack soft bags.

Pack

Reef-safe sunscreen, a light rain jacket, quick-dry everything, closed shoes for muddy trails, binoculars, a headlamp, and your own wax if you're particular.

What not to expect

~~ON-TIME ARRIVALS~~	Roads, rivers and cows run on their own schedule.
~~CHEAP~~	It was, in 1991. Well, now…
~~A DRY FOREST~~	It's called a rainforest for a reason.
~~CROWDED LINE-UPS~~	Not where we send you, and not at dawn.
~~HORNET-FREE RAFTERS~~	Mostly. Look up before you sit down.

Straight answers

Do I need to surf? No. But you'll want to by day three.

Can I drive myself? You can. I did, for years. Hire a driver.

Children? A great fit. Ages for rafting and ziplines `[confirm per operator]`.

Words you'll hear on the road

Pura vida

Pure life. Hello, goodbye, thank you, no worries, and the national philosophy.

Tico, Tica

A Costa Rican. Named, so the story goes, for a fondness for the diminutive "-tico".

Soda

A small family restaurant. Order the casado, the plate of the day.

Green season

The polite name for the rainy season, May to November. The forest's favourite.

Offshore

Wind blowing from land to sea, grooming the waves. Guanacaste's dry-season gift to surfers.

Panga

A small open boat. Your ride to Ollie's Point, and a few lodges.

Line-up

Where surfers wait for waves. Respect it, and it respects you.

Howler

The monkey that wakes you at 4.30 a.m. Louder than any alarm, and free.

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COLOPHON

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YOUR TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

Your journey, in your hand

When I'd like to go	
Who's coming	
Board, lodge or both	☐ The surf coast ☐ The wild interior ☐ The Contrast
The coast I circled	☐ Pacific ☐ Caribbean ☐ Over the border
Something to celebrate	

I KNOW A PLACE · THE WEEKLY LETTER

One place a week, from James's own book

New lodges, quiet breaks and the odd secret we don't print here. You're already on the list.

A LAST WORD FROM JAMES

Jane, that's Costa Rica as I've known it since 1991, from a stalled car in a river to a hot spring under a volcano. Circle what moves you, cross out what doesn't, and send it back to me. I'll read every mark and call you with a plan built around them. I've already taken every wrong turn in the country. You don't have to.

Til our next expedition,

James

JAMES PAPAGNO · CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER

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MAPS Engraved plates drawn by James Wild & Co. from Natural Earth public-domain data; surf-break positions approximate.
HISTORY Adventure Expeditions and the surf breaks mapped 1991–1994: from James Papagno's own logbooks and recollection. Some rivers may remember it differently.
SOURCES Arrivals: ICT figures via Wikipedia (1991) and La Nación (2025). Biodiversity and protected areas: Embassy of Costa Rica; SINAC. Army abolished 1948: Constitution of Costa Rica, Art. 12. Seasons and surf: The Surf Atlas, CR Surf, Surfer Today, Tourism Panama; turtles: ACTO/SINAC. Entry: US Department of State. Domestic airlines: SANSA; La Nación. Stays: Forbes Travel Guide, Black Tomato, i-escape, Four Seasons, Virtuoso, Timbuktu, Costa Rica Experts; confirm with each property before booking.
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FIELD GUIDE NO. 03
COSTA RICA · THE LONG WAY ROUND
EDITION 2027